

China: AI-related high-tech boosted May exports

- Exports beat expectations on strong high-tech shipments, with a growing price lift (memory chips/modules, AI datacenter equipment, and new energy).
- Imports firmed for a sixth month, driven more by AI supply-chain needs and commodity stockpiling than broad domestic-demand recovery.
- More narrowly product-focused and increasingly price-driven trade strength makes production and net export contribution to growth less clear-cut.
- The export outlook is supported by resilient global demand and a broadening of capex to non-tech, with a downside skew from renewed US tariff uncertainties (a pivot to Sections 301/232) and a tougher EU stance against China.

Echoing the [upside surprise in FX reserves](#), China's May exports beat expectations by a wide margin, lifted by shipments of high-tech and mechanical and electrical products. The official price-volume split will come in two weeks, but price gains in memory chips and modules, AI datacenter buildout equipment, and new energy products likely remained a meaningful boost. Imports expanded for a sixth straight month, likely driven by AI-related high-tech imports and commodity stockpiling. As price effects become more supportive, we believe that the read-through to domestic production and the net export contribution to growth is less clear-cut, more volatile, and more sensitive to [relative price moves and product mix](#).

Headline exports rose 3.1%/m/m sa, after April's 6.7% jump. Annual growth accelerated to 19.4%oya (vs. market consensus: 15%, JPM: 12.1%), though the trend pace slipped to -6.5%3m/3m saar on an unusually high February base. Imports expanded for a sixth straight month, up 2.9%/m/m sa, keeping annual growth elevated at 27.5%oya (vs. market consensus: 26%oya, JPM: 22.9%). Trend growth stayed strong at 57.8%3m/3m saar. The trade surplus widened to US \$105.4bn, lifting the ytd surplus to \$453bn (vs. \$470bn same period last year).

In the destination breakdown, exports logged solid gains across EM Asia (7.0%/m sa, led by 13.2% for Korea), Japan (6%), and the US (4.9%), alongside increases to Africa and Russia, despite a partial pullback in the EU (-1.5%). By product, low-end consumer goods (textiles, garments, toys, etc.) slipped 0.3%/m/m sa. High-tech shipments rose for the seventh consecutive month, up 8.0%/m/m sa, led by mobile phones (+19.4%), electronic integrated circuits (+15.2%), and ADP (automatic data processing, +11.0%). This likely reflects memory price inflation amid tight supply. Auto exports rose 2.2%/m/m sa, keeping annual growth strong at 39.3%.

After undershooting for most of 2025, imports have beaten expectations since December, averaging a 4.3% monthly run rate as of May. By origin, May gains were led by Asia (Korea +10.2%/m/m sa, Japan +2.9%), alongside Brazil and the US (+2.1%). By product, the pattern mirrors exports: high-tech imports rose 5.9%/m/m sa, helped by price effects, especially in memory products sourced from Korea. Commodity imports were mixed, with volume gains in coal, natural gas,

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soybeans, and copper, while crude oil and refined petroleum products continued to slide. The [decline in crude imports](#) partly reflects last year's reserve build and a preference to draw inventories. However, as the Middle East conflict drags on, a return toward more "normal" import levels could tighten the regional oil market.

Trade blows out, growth impact less clear-cut amid tariff risks

Trade strength year-to-date has far exceeded our prior expectations, which has prompted an [outlook recalibration](#). Granular breakdowns suggest the impulse is unusually narrow and increasingly price-driven. Export gains are concentrated in memory ICs and AI-linked storage/modules, alongside EVs, solar, and batteries, together accounting for around 60% of total export gains. Within this, semiconductor export prices have surged, with memory rotating from a volume-led story in 2025 to a price-led one in recent months. "New three" pricing (EV/solar/batteries) has also firmed, alongside solid volume growth. Elsewhere, average export prices turned marginally positive in April and could face further upward pressure from elevated energy costs. Imports, meanwhile, look less like a domestic-demand rebound and more like AI supply-chain pull and commodity stockpiling.

This mix makes the GDP and employment implications less straightforward. Net export contribution is likely smaller and more volatile, and more sensitive to relative price moves (chips, commodities, FX) and composition. Uncertainty is compounded by the risk that the US trade truce is not extended and by the prospect of new Section 301 tariffs.

After courts struck down earlier IEEPA and Section 122 tariffs, the Trump administration is pivoting to **Sections 301 and 232**, including probes into excess capacity across 16 economies and forced-labor enforcement across 60 economies. The measures are broader and faster-moving than the 2017–18 China tariff cycle and could still disproportionately hit China-linked supply chains. Trump's China visit delivered modest stabilization, creating new Board of Trade and Board of Investment channels, plus preliminary commitments on critical minerals, Boeing, and agriculture, but little substantive resolution. Up to four presidential summits this year may preserve a fragile floor under US-China relations. But with no joint statement, China calling the deals preliminary, and courts scrutinizing tariff authority, trade risk is likely to remain a prolonged source of uncertainty unless the new boards convert dialogue into finalized agreements before President Xi's scheduled visit to the US in September.

The risk of an **intensified EU–China trade conflict** is rising as [Europe's](#) political tone hardens and policymakers look for stronger tools to curb surging imports, especially in sectors where China is increasingly dominant (notably EVs and other strategic industries). A further escalation could bring tighter market access via trade-defense actions and industrial policy (e.g., subsidy design and eligibility rules that effectively exclude Chinese firms), raising the probability of slower China-to-EU export growth, greater destination re-routing, and more headline volatility driven by policy rather than underlying demand. Retaliation risk is also material as China has signaled willingness to respond to protective measures, and Europe is also sensitive to supply-chain leverage (e.g., rare-earth-related disruptions). For China's trade outlook, this points to an asymmetric and composition-driven profile. Categories already under scrutiny (autos/EVs, green energy, selected high-tech inputs) face higher downside skew, and the balance of risks is shifting towards policy shocks, tit-for-tat measures, and confidence effects on cross-border investment and supply-chain planning.

One upside for exports going forward is resilient external demand. Global growth has held up despite the energy shock, supported by policy cushioning, a still-solid consumer, and a business sentiment lift as last year's trade-war drag fades. The key shift is that capex strength is [broadening](#) beyond AI infrastructure into non-tech spending, AI adoption across industries, manufacturing, and potential inventory rebuilds, helped by strong profits and lean

stock positions. For China, a firmer global goods and capex cycle should support export momentum and China-linked supply chains, partly offsetting uneven domestic demand.

Barring a sharp pullback, this year's nominal export growth could land in the high single digits, and potentially above 10%. Meanwhile, imports are also firming, partly on renewed stockpiling and AI supply-chain inputs, raising the likelihood that full-year nominal import growth outpaces exports for the first time since 2021.

Merchandise trade

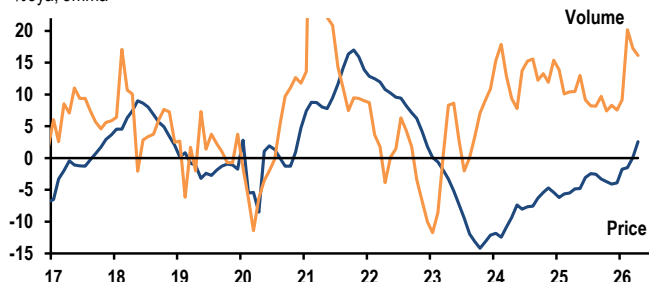
US\$ billion and percent change

	2025	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26
Exports					
\$ billion	3770.5	299.8	321.0	359.4	376.8
%oya	5.4	39.6	2.5	14.1	19.4
%m/m, sa		21.2	-18.8	6.7	3.1
Imports					
\$ billion	2587.8	209.3	270.5	274.6	271.3
%oya	0.1	14.0	28.1	25.3	27.5
%m/m, sa		3.3	4.4	2.4	2.9
Trade balance					
\$ billion	1182.8	90.5	50.6	84.8	105.4

Source: Customs Statistics, J.P. Morgan

Exports volume vs. price (US\$)

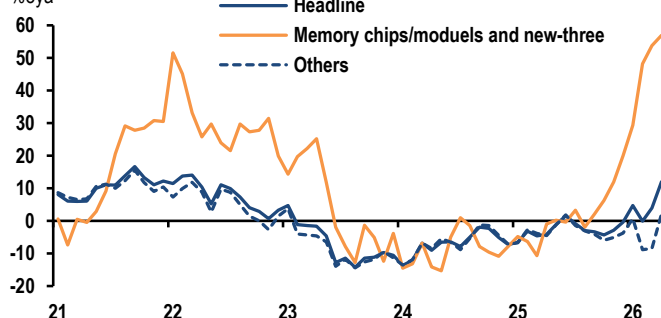
%oya, 3mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Export price breakdown (in US\$ terms)

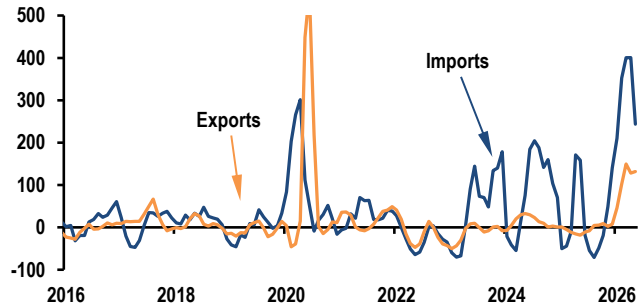
%oya



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Automatic data processing machines & unit

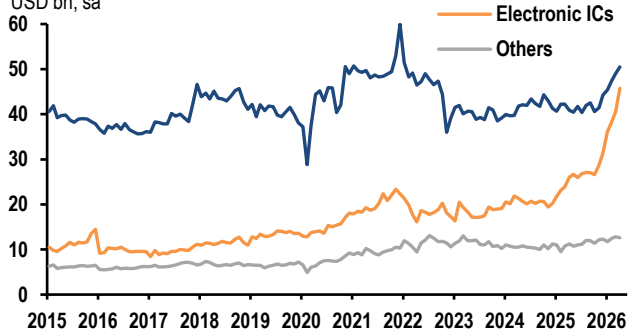
%3m/3m saar



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China's high-tech exports

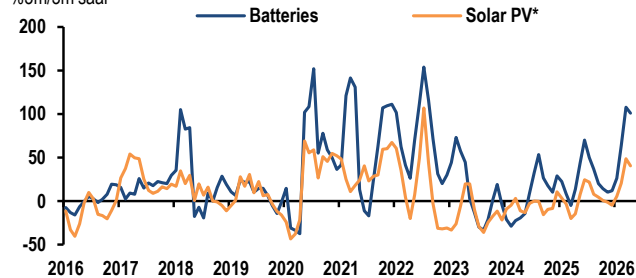
USD bn, sa



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China battery and solar PV exports

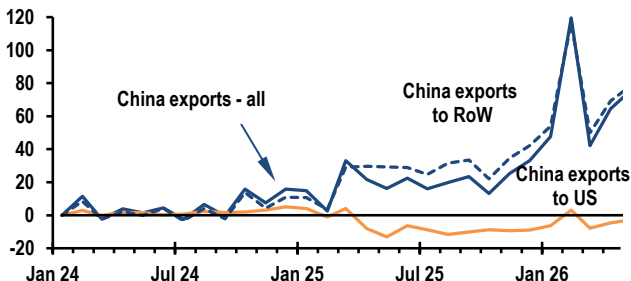
%3m/3m saar



Source: CEIC, J.P. Morgan. *Estimates at HS4-digit level

China exports to US and RoW

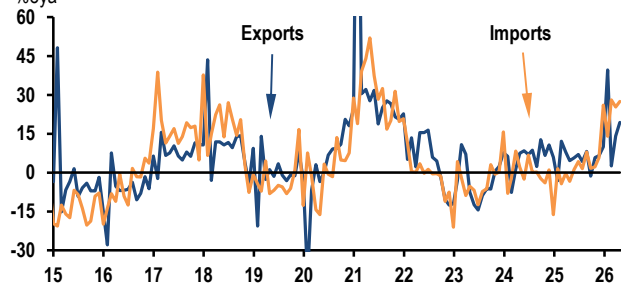
\$bn sa, chg from Jan 2024 level



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China merchandise trade growth

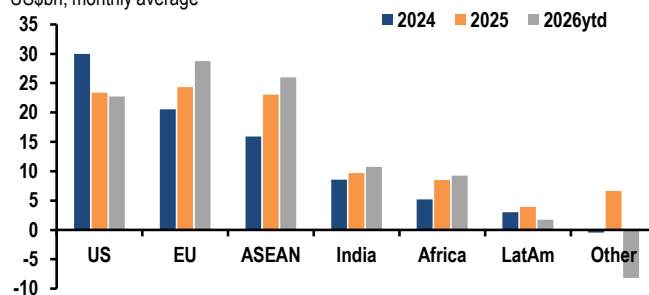
%oya



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China trade surplus by partner

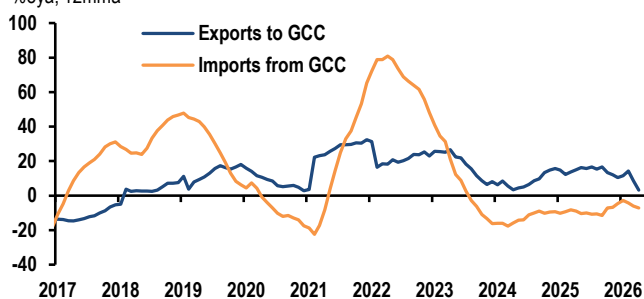
US\$bn, monthly average



Source: NBS, J.P. Morgan

China's trade with GCC - growth rate

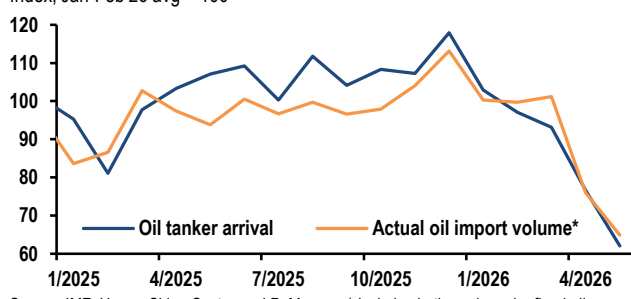
%oya, 12mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China's oil imports

Index, Jan-Feb 26 avg = 100



Source: IMF, Haver, China Customs, J.P. Morgan. * Includes both crude and refined oil

China exports to US vs. US imports from China

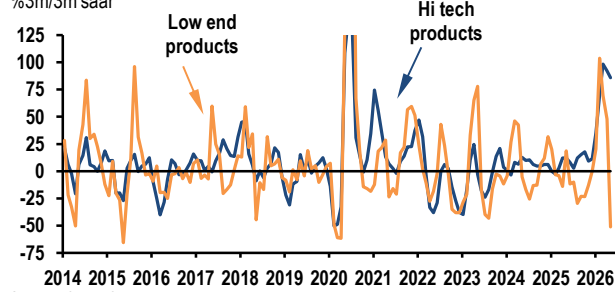
US\$bn



Source: China Customs, Census Bureau, J.P. Morgan

China: Major export categories

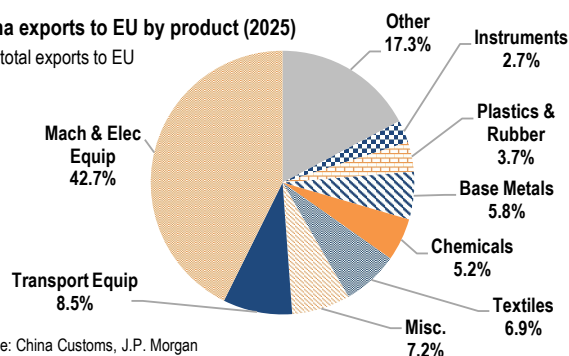
%3m/3m saar



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China exports to EU by product (2025)

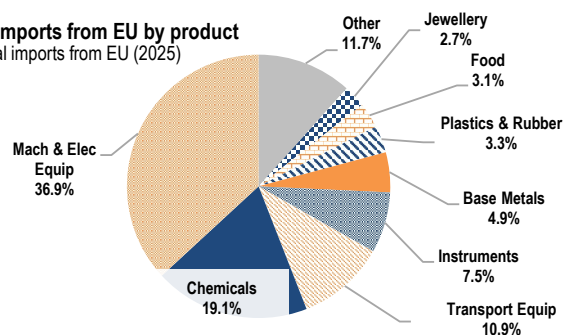
% of total exports to EU



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

China imports from EU by product

% of total imports from EU (2025)



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan

Merchandise exports breakdown

Percent change

		2025	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26
EU	%oya	8.5	54.9	8.6	13.4	7.6
	%m/m, sa		16.4	-14.3	4.3	-1.5
US	%oya	-19.8	9.7	-26.5	11.3	35.4
	%m/m, sa		26.7	-24.4	9.4	4.9
Japan	%oya	3.6	22.5	3.3	4.0	10.9
	%m/m, sa		7.9	-4.7	-1.2	6.0
EM Asia	%oya	10.5	37.5	11.4	17.7	27.9
	%m/m, sa		11.6	-10.1	4.7	7.0
Russia	%oya	-10.5	59.0	20.6	25.7	35.8
	%m/m, sa		24.3	-9.2	1.8	7.3
Africa	%oya	25.7	97.5	3.1	17.3	18.6
	%m/m, sa		62.5	-38.8	6.6	4.3
LatAm	%oya	7.4	44.1	-3.7	13.7	6.1
	%m/m, sa		25.0	-19.2	12.8	-6.6
Main export product categories						
Low-end consumer goods						
	%oya	-3.8	69.0	-30.4	-1.8	-2.8
	%m/m, sa		40.2	-39.8	16.8	-0.3
Mechanical and electrical products						
	%oya	8.2	43.7	11.2	20.3	27.4
	%m/m, sa		13.4	-10.8	5.5	4.9
Hi-tech products						
	%oya	7.3	30.2	31.4	39.2	50.9
	%m/m, sa		6.5	3.5	4.5	8.0

Source: China Customs; J.P. Morgan

Merchandise imports by country

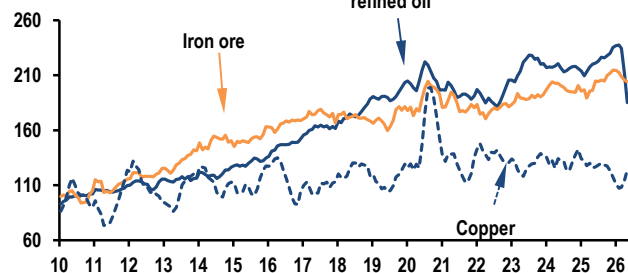
Percent change

	2025	Feb 26	Mar 26	Apr 26	May 26
EU					
%oya	-0.4	-3.0	8.5	14.5	-1.3
%m/m, sa		-7.2	0.2	0.9	-0.7
US					
%oya	-14.9	-26.3	1.0	9.0	20.4
%m/m, sa		11.1	8.6	13.0	2.1
Japan					
%oya	5.5	8.6	35.2	21.0	29.2
%m/m, sa		-7.3	9.5	0.1	2.9
EM Asia					
%oya	1.4	16.4	25.2	34.6	38.0
%m/m, sa		4.4	6.7	5.9	2.5
Brazil					
%oya	4.5	20.9	39.0	38.1	15.5
%m/m, sa		-3.5	-11.8	12.4	2.2
Australia					
%oya	-1.7	41.6	87.6	31.5	20.5
%m/m, sa		1.8	19.7	-8.8	-5.4

Source: China Customs; J.P. Morgan

China commodity import volume

Index, 2010=100, sa, 3mma



Source: General Administration of Customs, J.P. Morgan

China automobile trade

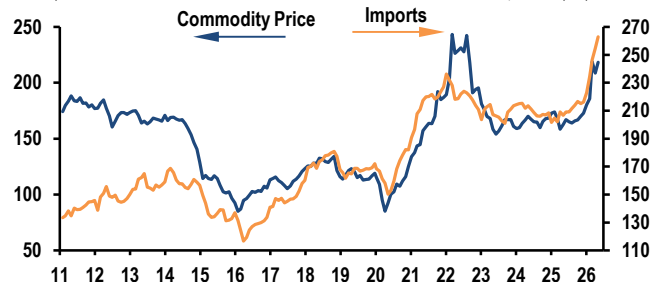
US\$, %oya, 3mma



Source: China Customs, J.P. Morgan.

China imports

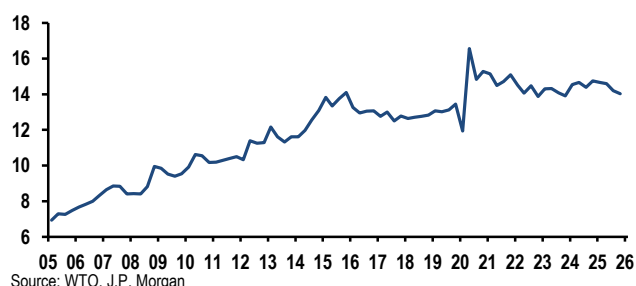
Index, sa



Source: China Customs, IMF, J.P. Morgan

China's share in global exports

%, sa



Source: WTO, J.P. Morgan

Major commodity imports (volume)

percent change

	2025	Feb-26	Mar-26	Apr-26	May-26
Crude Petroleum Oil					
%oya	4.6	12.6	-2.8	-20.0	-29.0
%m/m, sa		-0.3	0.6	-26.9	-3.8
%m/m, nsa		-1.7	4.0	-23.0	-14.0
Refined Petroleum Products					
%oya	-12.9	49.8	19.3	-49.3	-58.1
%m/m, sa		12.9	-28.0	-52.8	-20.1
%m/m, nsa		12.2	-23.8	-50.3	-28.0
Natural Gas	-3.0				
%oya		-10.6	-10.7	-12.9	0.0
%m/m, sa		-10.2	-0.3	-1.0	7.2
%m/m, nsa		-25.6	-4.2	2.9	20.0
Soybean					
%oya	6.5	2.6	14.9	39.5	-15.3
%m/m, sa		16.9	-14.2	25.2	5.6
%m/m, nsa		-9.0	-32.8	110.9	39.0
Iron Ore					
%oya	1.8	3.6	11.5	0.7	-0.4
%m/m, sa		-4.0	1.2	-1.3	-2.3
%m/m, nsa		-13.1	7.3	-0.8	-5.9
Copper					
%oya	-6.2	-23.8	-10.6	2.3	3.6
%m/m, sa		-3.5	9.7	11.1	4.5
%m/m, nsa		-15.8	31.3	7.1	-1.0
Aluminum					
%oya	4.8	-9.4	5.9	-2.7	
%m/m, sa		15.8	2.1	-3.0	
%m/m, nsa		-6.5	24.1	0.0	
Coal					
%oya	-9.6	-10.0	0.9	-12.6	-7.7
%m/m, sa		-11.3	3.9	-19.4	11.8
%m/m, nsa		-33.1	26.2	-15.3	0.6
Steel Products					
%oya	-11.4	-32.7	2.0	-9.6	-6.1
%m/m, sa		-10.8	17.5	-6.2	-0.9
%m/m, nsa		-19.6	37.8	-7.8	-4.1
Mechanical & electrical products (value)					
%oya	5.0	17.5	25.9	33.5	38.2
%m/m, sa		1.4	4.2	6.6	6.0
%m/m, nsa		-14.0	37.0	4.9	0.3
Hi-tech products (value)					
%oya	9.0	23.7	31.5	41.9	46.8
%m/m, sa		2.0	5.9	8.0	5.9
%m/m, nsa		-13.1	41.3	4.5	0.7

Source: Customs statistics, J.P.Morgan

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09 June 2026

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